The Lost City of Half-moon

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), glimmer - Relationship, Bow - Relationship, Cyra - Relationship, Nala - Relationship

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The Lost City of Half-moon

by Praxiteles

Summary

"For the Honor of Grayskull!" Adora says, and then she's standing there as a legendary warrior. Sword resting on her shoulder and a hand on her cocked hip, she smirks down at the soldier.

The feline has covered her face with her hand, her tail swishes back and forth behind her. She grumbles again but this time Adora can make it out.

"What the actual fuck"

or Adora takes Catra on the best not-date of her life.

or my take on 'ilikeyoucatradora's Halfmoon au post found here:

https://www.instagram.com/p/CuAZreEgV5a/?utm_source=ig_web_copy_link&igshid=MzRlODBiNWFlZA==

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

Strong hands on either side of her force Adora down to her knees. The restraints holding her arms behind her back chaff and dig into her skin. Her knees dig into the rocky surface they forced her on. She grunts as she’s shoved into a bow.

“quítate la bolsa” (*take off the bag*) a scratchy female voice says. The language is foreign and unlike any Adora has heard. The cloth covering her eyes and face is ripped to the side. Adora has to squint to see through the sunlight shining on her.

“Quién eres?”(*who are you?*) before Adora is a masked and furred figure. Not just covered in fur but wearing fur. The skin of a razor fin draped over their body, its head resting on top of the red mask in a permanted growl. The mask is golden accented and looks suspiciously like a cat.

“Wha-” Adora mumbles, squinting at the figure through the light.

“¿Qué estás haciendo aquí?”(*what are you doing here?*) Adora shakes her head.

“I don't understand” the figure looks at the large thing beside the Adora. Another figure also covered in fur but nearly as impressive. A pooka with a stone eye draped over their shoulders.

“donde la conseguiste?”(*where did you find her?*) the figure asks, gesturing to Adora with a clawed hand. The figure's shoulders and forearms are covered in thick golden armor. Little half moons trailing up the sides.

“Ella estaba en el bosque. casi caminó hacia el sol de Saz." (*she was in the forest. Almost walked into The Sun of Saz*) The figure before Adora grunts in acknowledgement and leans closer. Its mask inches from Adora 's face.

“Who are you?” Their force is slow and accented. They tilt their head to the side as Adora hesitates.

“I'm Adora” the blonde leans back as the thing reaches up towards Adora’s cheek. instead of slapping or hitting her the hand brushes her cheek and then they tug on her ear.

“los humanos realmente tienen un aspecto divertido”(*humans really do look funny)* it mutters, Adora winces as they tug a little too hard.

“What were you doing stomping around The Sun of Saz?” they ask, leaning away from Adora just a smidge.

“The Sun of who?” Adora asks, shifting in her uncomfortable position. The figure tilts their head again, this time the other direction. Adora flinches a little as the figure reaches up, pausing at Adora’s reaction.

They reach their mask and gently pull it off, the skin of the razor fin coming with it. A beautiful cat hybrid crouches before Adora. Brown fur with tan stripes and two pierced ears flicker on her head. Two intelligent mismatched eyes glare into Adora’s. Her lips are twisted in a snarl.

“The Sun if Saz” she repeats, the sunlight glancing off her pointed canines. “Were you planning on stealing it? Destroying it?”

Adora shakes her head quickly, breaking from her trance, “no! No, I had no idea anything was over there! I swear” the girl's eyebrows draw together as if she doesn't believe Adora. She turns back to the hulking figure beside Adora.

“Tigger, ¿qué te parece? ¿Horda?” (*Tigger, what do you think? Horde?*) she asks, gesturing to the sword the thing holds in its massive grip. The figure lifts the sharp object with ease and flips it around in its hands.

“no, la horda suele tener armas.” (*no, Horde usually have guns*)The thing's voice is low and booming, slightly muffled by the purple mask covering its face. “This is just some piece of junk”

Adora scoffs, the three assailants turn to her, “piece of junk? That's the sword of protection!”

“creo que ella es linda” (*i think she’s cute)* the smaller figure beside her speaks up. Her voice is cheery and young. “¿Podemos quedarnos con ella?”(*can we keep her?*)

“It's an old sword” the girl in front of her gestures to it. “It looks duller than a rock”

“Look, my friends and I came here looking for the Princess of Half-moon.” the first girl looks up at her companions. “Do you know where I can find her?

“You don't just find the princess of half moon” the girl scoffs. planting her hands on her hips. two dual swords rest there. Glinting in the little sun flitting through the space.

“Well you kinda do” the huling figure beside Adora laughs.

‘ciérralo” (*shut it*) the feline growls. “So, there’s more of you?”

“Uhhhh, no?” A slow smile spreads across the girl's face and she tilts her head as she looks at Adora. She had never been good liar and now is probably no better. She turns towards her companions.

“Busca en el bosque más idiotas torpes” (*Search the woods for more bumbling idiots*) she glances to Adora out of the corner of her eye. “I'll take her back to Half-moon”

——

They put the bag back over Adora’s head, speaking rapid fire in their foreign language. Then Adora is alone with the feline. Well at least she thinks. The only steps she can hear are her own stumbling wanderings and the girls gracefully pads.

The silence is starting to get to her. Mostly the non silence of it. Birds Adora can identify chirp and squeal high pitched and

deafeningly. The brushes and trees bristle and flutter. Wind howls between thick barked trunks and makes Adora think people are whispering.

“Uh so,” Adora starts, turning towards where she thinks her captor is. “What’s your name?”

A soft chuckles comes from her other side. She tilts her head inconspicuously to that side. “I'm not going to tell you that”

“Why not?

“Uh because you’re very likely to be a Horde spy” Adora scoffs, straightening her shoulders

“I'm not,” she slouches a little. “…Well not anymore” the girl laughs, grabbing Adora’s arm and pulling her to the side. Adora almost stumbles as her foot hits the edge of a.. log?

“What do you mean not anymore? Once a Horde soldier, always a Horde soldier.”

“I defected! I'm with the rebellion now for your information.” Adora pouts.

“Oh, I'm so sorry, I had no idea with that Horde insignia branded across your back.” The girl snarks.

“It’s a comfortable shirt! And… I'm usually wearing a jacket.” Adora tries to look over her shoulder at the mark, forgetting she’s wearing a bag over her head.

“Yeah, yeah.”

“I’ll have you know that I'm.. I'm She-ra” Adora still hasn’t gotten used to admitting that. For her whole life she’s just been regular old Adora. But now suddenly she has to introduce herself as a completely different person.

There’s a pause. An extending silence where even the birds and little critters around them hesitate.

And then the girl burst out laughing. the birds start to screech again, as if agreeing with her. She grabs onto Adora's arm and pulls her to a stop as she belly laughs like there’s no tomorrow. It's squeaky and high pitched, tiny snorts finding their places when she tries to take a breath.

“Y- your- " hysterical giggling breaks up her sentence. Adora sighs and rolls her eyes.

“Yeah yeah, laugh it up”. Her shoulders slouch a little bit and she kicks at the dirt. “I really am She-ra. It’s like a whole thing.”

The girl seems to be half bent over in her attempt to catch her breath. Her giggling peters out. “You want me to believe- that your skinny ass is She-ra!?”

“Well I'm bigger when I transform”

“Then do it! Prove it”

“Ok, give me my sword.”

“I'm sorry- I'm not going to give, an admittedly dull weapon, to a Horde soldier. Previous or no”

“Then I can’t prove it!”

“Oh I see what this is. this is a ruse! Clever, clever” the girl grabs her arm and starts to move again.

“Why don’t you tell the Queen all about being She-ra. We’re almost there.” The words start to become echoey and instead of tramping through mossy grass, Adora’s steps begin to hollow and clop onto rock.

“She-ra” the girl mumbles, another small laugh escaping her, “that one was good, I'v never had a Horde soldier try to pull that one

on me.”

“Do you get a lot of Horde here?” Adora asks, stumbling over a rock. The girl reaches out and grabs her arm. Keeping her upright.

She hesitates, as if she’s thinking about her response or if she’s going to respond at all.

“The Horde has been more present recently” she mutters. It’s muffled, as if she’s looking away. “Snooping around the ruins, using technology to scan the woods”

Scanning the woods? The only thing out here is the lost city of Half-moon. Half-moon that the rebellion has only just recently discovered still exists.

“Sounds like they’re scouting for Half-moon” Adora says, turning towards her captor. That’s bad, very bad. That means The Horde knows Half-moon still lives, and will do anything to destroy it.

“No shit” the girl mumbles, directing Adora to the right. her grip pulls Adora to a stop.

“Su Alteza Real" (*your royal highness*) a gruff voice says. The sound of metal on metal screeches through the cave. A door opening.

“Tigger y Calico deberían estar en camino en breve.”(Tigger and Calico should be on their way shortly) Catra says, pulling Adora through.

“alertará a la reina de su llegada.”(*i will alert the queen)*

“Gracias Oscar.”

—--

The queen is beautiful. Black fur with white spots.. She isn't wearing armor like the soldiers that brought Adora in nor is she

wearing a fur. On her hips she's strapped two dual swords. Similar to the ones the soldier that brought her here wears.

Standing next to Adora that very feline bows her head. "Su majestad, este espía de la Horda fue encontrado incómodamente cerca del Sol de Saz" (Your Majesty, this Horde spy was found uncomfortably close to the Sun of Saz)

She looks up, presenting the sword to the Queen.

"She had this strapped to her back, she claims she is the legendary She-ra." the Queen quirks a smile at that. Looking down at Adora, Not unkindly.

"What is your name?" the queen asks, standing from her throne. Adora bows her head.

"Adora of Brightmoon." the Queen's eyebrows rise at that. A sly smile slipping onto her face.

"What would a representative of Brightmoon need from the Sun of Saz?"

"Nothing you majesty! It was a mistake, me and my friends are here looking for you!" The Queen stands from her throne and clasps her hands behind her back.

"Well now that you have me, What do you want?" when she reaches the dual eye soldier and caress her cheek with a smile. The girl relaxes her stance.

"We're here to recruit Princess D'rulith of half-moon to the Princess Alliance." Both the Queen and the soldier freeze.

"The Princess Alliance was disbanded nearly 20 years ago."

The door bursts open and in stumbles the large figure from earlier. His mask is off now, showing off orange fur and white spots. one hand has a firm grip on Glimmer. Her hands are shackled in purple glowing cuffs. Unlike the rope that holds Adora.

“I do not like teleporting” is what he states upon entrance, breathing deeply and looking a little like he’s going to throw up. Glimmer smirks and raises an eyebrow,

“Some people just can’t handle it”

Bow walks in behind them, his hands aren't even bound. He chats animatedly with the smaller figure. A girl with black fur and white spots.

Adora turns back to the queen who’s smiling at the new arrivals. “I see you brought us some more guests. One of which is the Princess of Brightmoon”

The large feline freezes and looks down at Glimmer. “Princess?” he squeaks, eyeing the shackles encasing her hands. She smiles up at him. He gulps and turns towards the Queen.

“Please take off her restraints, Tigger.” he quickly does as told, refusing to look at the smirking Glimmer. The girl next to Adora bends and rips through her restraints with a claw.

Adora smiles in thanks and flexes her fingers, rubbing the feeling back into them.

“Princess Glimmer of Brightmoon, I hear you're looking for my daughter.” Glimmer stands beside Adora and bends into a bow.

“Yes, your majesty, we’re here to ask if she would join the new Rebellion and fight with us against the Horde.” The Queen turns towards the soldier that brought Adora in, an eyebrow raised. The feline scoffs and moves to stand closer to Adora. eyeing her as if she doesn't trust anything they're saying.

“What does the Rebellion bring to the table that it didn't have before?” Th Queen asks, Adora smirks cockily at the soldier that brought her in as Glimmer answers.

“She-ra, the Princess of power.” Glimmer says, the soldier winces and looks away. “Adora? If you would.”

Adora holds out her hand for the sword and the soldier begrudgingly gives it to her, grumbling in their native language.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” Adora says, and then she’s standing there as a legendary warrior. Sword resting on her shoulder and a hand on her cocked hip, she smirks down at the soldier.

The feline has covered her face with her hand, her tail swishes back and forth behind her. She grumbles again but this time Adora can make it out.

“What the actual fuck”

“It's not often Catra is proven wrong” the Queen chuckles, throwing an arm over the soldier's shoulder. Catra, a little on the nose but adorable.

“I'm sure D’rulith will be intrigued by your offer, but you'll have to ask her yourself.” She steps away from the group and towards the door. “Now I must go find my wife, why don't these three give you a tour of Half-moon. As an apology for mistaking your identities.”

Catra looks like she’s going to murder someone. she glares at the Queen, which Adora’s pretty sure might be treason.

“It would be my pleasure” she says, turning from the Queen and handing her cloak and fur to the throne room guard.

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“So.. Do you know Princess D’rulith?” Adora asks, turning towards Catra. She looks perfectly at home walking through the town square. Her armor shining in the light of the rocky ceiling.

That one had been a shock, stones that covered the expanse of the cave Half-moon resides in. The town was situated on the floor of the cave, a mineral water river flowing through the center. The town square is just after the bridge that crosses the rushing water. The far stone walls littered with tunnels and openings that could lead anywhere.

You could say that” Catra murmurs, waving to another townsperson. The girl seems to know everyone.

“What’s she like?" Adora asks, dodging to the side and pressing into Catra as a trio of children run past her. The feline doesn't say anything about their brushing arms but she does eye the place where they touch.

“I think she’s a brat” Tigger speaks up from beside Catra. A wide smile on his face as he looks right at Catra.

Said feline's hand strikes out quick as lighting. Catra digs her hand into Tigger's side hard enough for him to grunt and stop his walk, leaning over on his hands and knees.

“Ouch” he wheezes.

“She’s ok,” Catra says, walking on like nothing happened.

“Adora!” Bow slides up next to her with a smile. “Calico is going to show me and Glimmer the dam, you wanna come?” Adora glances at the excitable girl next to Bow.

The thought of roaring water and moist air makes Adora cringe, apparently it makes Catra cringe too, her tail all puffed up. She discreetly smooths it down with her hand, looking away from the group.

“Naw, I wanna see what kind of food they got” she smiles as Catra visibly relaxes. “You guys go on ahead without me”

Bow shrugs and pulls Glimmer after him as they follow Calico through the crowd of people. Tigger waves and jogs after them, one hand still on his stomach.

The sound of giggling makes Adora lift her head in front of them. The crowd of magicats in the center square is thick but thin enough that Adora can see little heads poking out behind a street vendor. They eye Catra and Adora with mischievous smiles.

Adora opens her mouth to make a comment but Catra looks at her and raises an eyebrow.

“Don't say anything.“ she says, passing the vendor the kittens were hiding behind. Adora gives it a fleeting glance, her eyes widening as she finds it empty.

Catra shrieks beside her and Adora jumps. She didn't jump as nearly as high as Catra did when the kit pounced on her.

“Oh no, you’ve got me” she moans, clutching at her heart with her hands. She dramatically staggers. “I don’t think I'll make it,” she falls to her knees and clutches the cute little girl that latched herself onto Catra. “Please, tell my mother… that... I love her”

Adora giggles but once she feels little claws digging into her shoulders she takes Catra’s lead.

“Oh my goodness,” she says, falling to her knees. “A fatal wound.” Catra holds back a smile at Adora’s poor acting. “I can't go on”

The kits giggle and pull Catra and Adora up by their hands.

“Will you play with us?” the kit that jumped onto Catra asks, her fur is gray and striped. She sticks out her bottom lip at Adora and furrows her brows. Adora's mouth drops open, her heart squeezing. Catra laughs behind her hand.

“I- “ Adora looks at Catra with puppy dog eyes. “Only if Catra says it's ok” she concedes. The little girl pops up and stands beside her with her own puppy dog eyes.

Catra smirks and crosses her arms, “you think a couple of pitiful puppy cat eyes-” she looks down as the second girl tugs on her hand. She has striped orange fur.

“Catra, there’s no one to play with at the orphanage” Adora’s heart breaks and from the looks of it Catra’s does too. She squeezes her eyes shut and crouches down to the girl, pulling her into a hug.

“It gets me everytime.” she whispers, the little girl giggles evilly and and wiggles in Catra’s arms.

“Come on” the little girl next to Adora takes her hand and drags her towards the square center.

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“My arms burn” Adora mumbles, rubbing at her muscles and staggering after Catra. The soldier seems unfazed by the workout those two little girls put them through. A game of tag that involves trees and the inability to touch the ground. It was the scariest half hour of Adora’s life.

Catra chuckles next to her and smiles her cheeky little smile. She’s been doing that a lot. Smiling at Adora. It's been making her heart palpitate, just a little.

“Let’s get something to eat,” she says, taking Adora’s hand and pulling her towards a group of street vendors. Catra’s hand is warm and firm. Muscles rip under the fur of her forearm. Adora smiles and follows after her.

Catra stops in front of a vendor that smells so good that Adora's knees almost buckle.

“dos brochetas por favor”(*two sticks please*) she says, to the man behind the counter, the language rolling off her tongue. The man smiles when he sees her and quickly pulls to stick packed with meat from his stand,

“su alteza, sería un placer” he says, handing them over. Catra pulls a handful of coins from her side bag but the man starts to furiously refuse. Catra rolls her eyes and takes his hand placing the money in his palm.

“Have a nice day, Tim” she winks at him and pulls Adora away from the crowd. She sees the man look down at the money with wide eyes and a smile.

Catra pulls her in between two vendors and leans against the wall of one. Adora leans against the other.

“Here” Catra says, handing one of the sticks to Adora. She takes it with furrowed eyebrows.

“What is it?” she asks, giving the meat and vegetables a sniff. Her eyes water and she lets out a cough at the spice filling her nose.

“What? The almighty She-ra can't handle the heat?” Catra asks, taking a bite from hers no problem. Adora scoffs and straightens.

“Can't handle the heat? I can handle anything..” she mutters, looking at the kabab. She winces and takes a bite.

Flavor and heat explodes across her tongue and she closes her eyes to the tears trying to break free. She nods with a genuinely pleased hum. But it comes out a little watery. Catra chuckles as Adora turns away.

She outright laughs as Adora starts to cough, her face going bright red.

“It tastes so good but hurts so bad,” Adora says, looking up at the soldier. Catra smiles and turns to the vendor she’s leaning against, exchanging a few coins for a steaming cup. She turns and hands it to Adora.

“Take it slow, this is a little hot.” Adora nods and blows out the steam before taking a hesitant sip. She hums appreciatively as the heat from the kabab cools. The drink is delicious, bursting with flavor.

“What is this?” she asks, nodding to the cup.

“Caldo,” Catra says, finishing off her kabab. “It's a kind of broth” Adora closes her eyes and takes a bite of meat, quickly taking a sip after to cool the heat. It's exceptional.

“It's amazing,” she says, smiling at the soldier. Catra smiles back, her canines glinting. She’s looking at Adora like she’s a little surprised.

Adora whips her head around to the sound of cracking. Her eyes widen as a vendor across the street tries to stop their shop from falling over. Catra hurries over to them. Adora hot on her heels, setting the drink and food down on the counter of the vendor next to her and pulling out her sword.

Catra looks up in surprise as the side of the tent she was holding up as high as she could is suddenly taken from her. She-ra smiles and winks. Catra’s tail whips from side to side.

“Thank you! Thank you” the shopkeeper says, handing Adora a support to set underneath the corner of the tent. She secures it to the ground and then the tent before letting go.

She smiles as the shopkeeper grabs her hands, her eyes widening as she’s pulled down by their surprisingly strong grip. The lady is very old, covered in graying orange fur. She gasps when she sees Adora's eyes and turns towards Catra.

“Su Alteza! tu novia es muy bonita" (*your majesty! Your girlfriend is very pretty*) Catra straightens, her fur puffing up and her tail going back and forth quickly.

“Yo- ella- Ella no es mi novia.” (*I- she-she is not my girlfriend*) the shopkeeper nods knowingly and pats Adora’s hands with a wink.

“Mantén a este fuera de problemas, ¿sí?”(*keep this one out of trouble, yeah?*) Adora nods even though she has no idea what the lady just said. Catra rolls her eyes and takes Adora’s hand from the shopkeeper, pulling her away.

Adora smiles down at the soldier, shrinking down to her normal height. “She was nice”

“Yes, very nice,” Catra says sarcastically. Adora can’t seem to pull her eyes away from the soldier. Her iris’s glint in the rock light, her fur and maine look so soft to the touch.

Adora shakes her head and looks away. Right into a circle of dancers.

“Catra!” she says, nudging the soldier and pointing to the party. “Can we do that?” she asks, pulling out her best puppy dog eyes. Catra glances over and grimaces.

“Did you even know any Half-moon dances?” she asks, turning towards Adora with a raised eyebrow. Adora shrugs.

“How hard could it be?”

It turns out, very hard. Adora steps on Catra’s feet multiple times, accidentally knocking into people and making Catra stumble even more times. The Soldier takes it in stride. Only hissing silently as Adora steps on her toes and smiling and apologizing when they bump into people.

It's fun. A lot of fun. Catra is a good lead, placing her hands on Adora’s hips and directing her around the circle. She gets pretty good at maneuvering Adora around other people. The dance seems to consist of quick steps and movements as they shift around the circle.

Catra quietly whispers to Adora which one is next and then laughs as the blond tries to perform it. Adora stumbles almost taking Catra down with her but the soldier laughs and spins them around and out of the dance circle.

Catra securly places her hands on Adora’s hips to keep her upright. The blonde giggles right along with her. She looks down into Catra’s mismatched eyes. There is a little scar just above her brow and another on her chin.

Catra smiles and tilts her head at the blond.

Adora’s head whips to the side at the sounds of bells. The rocks on the ceiling seem to have dimmed, turning into deep purples and pinks.

“Looks like they're rafting” Catra murmurs and Adora follows her eyes to the lake. People climb onto boats and rafts, setting onto the water. Adora gasps.

“Catra can we-”

“Absolutely not,” Catra says, pulling away from Adora. The blonde didn't even realize they were still embracing. Her arms feel cold without Catra’s warm fur.

“But-”

“No, I am not getting on a rickety old boat” Catra crosses her arms and turns away from the water. Her fur puffing up a little and her eyes shifting. Adora’s eyes widen.

“You're scared of water?”

“I'm not scared” Catra growls, her fur puffing even worse. Adora smiles and takes her hand.

“I wouldn't let you drown” she says, Catra rolls her eyes at that and looks away.

“I'm not scared of water,” she says, glancing down at the lake.

“You're not scared, I'm just saying that if you perhaps happened to fall in, which won't happen! I would probably ‘fall’ in after you.” Catra chuckles and gently pulls her hand from Adora’s grip.

“ok, ok fine. But only for 20 minutes. And your rowing”

“30”

“25” Catra raises an eyebrow and Adora smiles. The soldier rolls her eyes.

She rents a little wooden boat from a vendor, heckling in rapid fire and winning from the looks of it. Though it seemed the shopkeeper was surprised that Catra was going out and relented.

Adora gets in first and holds out her hand to help Catra in. The girl stands on the dock rubbing the fur on her other arm.

“I won't let you fall,” Adora says, holding her hand out further. Catra takes a deep breath and cringes as she takes Adora’s hand, stepping into the boat. She lets out a little squeak as it rocks but keeps her balance and the death grip on Adora’s hand.

Adora smiles and sits down with her, her back to the tip of the boat. Catra grips the side of the boat with her other hand and hesitantly looks over the side and into the clear blue water.

“Stars, how did I let you talk me into this?" she says, quickly looking away and into Adora’s eyes. Adora smiles and looks down at her hand.

“I kinda need my hand to row.” The resulting ‘brrt” Catra lets out before quickly ripping her hand away makes Adora chuckle. Catra lets out a warning growl and grips the side of the boat.

She squeezes her eyes shut as Adora starts to row. Pushing them off from the dock. Adora makes sure to keep her strokes slow and steady. The reflection of the water ripples and dissipates.

Catra slowly opens her eyes as the boat floats to a stop. The reflection in the water slowly comes back, creating a mirror image of the rocks on the ceiling.

“Woah” Adora says, her eyes fixed where the crystals bleed from blue to purple to pink and back again. Catra turns her head to look two, her eyes widening at the sight.

Adora looks over at an intake of breath. The light reflects off the water and illuminates Catra in the colors. Her fur glows a soft purple. her eyes reflecting a vibrant pink. Her lips are parted slightly, showing off her sharp canines. She’s beautiful.

Catra’s eyes glint to hers and she furrowed her eyebrows, “what?”

Adora shrugs and looks back out at the water. “Nothing?” Adora says, folding her hands in her lap. Catra raises an eyebrow at her.

“Why the fear- aversion to water?” Adora asks, Catra shrinks a little in her seat, lifting her legs onto the bench next to her and folding her arms atop them.

Adora tilts her head and waits. It doesn't take Catra long to glance over to her and sigh.

“You see the rapids?” she asks, pointedly to where the water leads into the lake, Adora nods.

“It goes all the way out of the cave and.. Well… let's just say it runs right past an old Horde compound.” She rests her chin on her folded arms and looks away from the water.

“When I was a kitten, I went in the water, up there. Alone and without a boat or raft or really the ability to swim. Almost drowned trying to stay afloat through the rapids. ended up here in the lake, I was fished out by the boat vendor.”

Adora winces and gazes at the river. The rapids are large enough to crash into each other and over the sides of the bank. It causes white bubbles to feed into the lake.

“I can swim now though,” Catra admits, raising a brow at the lake. “Best swimmer in Half-moon.”

‘Yeah? Think you could beat me?” Adora asks, smirking at the soldier.

“There is no way in hell you getting me in that water” Catra deadpans. Adora leans back on her hands with a smile.

“So, how’d you get the She-ra gig” she asks, gesturing to the sword strapped to Adora’s back.

“Wasn't really a choice” Adora says, the sword on her back feels heavier. “More like I found it in the woods and then poof, I was in a tiara” Catra smiles and leans forward.

Neither of them seem to want to stop talking after that. Catra’s threat of only twenty five minutes melts into thirty, and then an hour, then two. Before they know it, they're the only two on the lake, laughing their hearts out.

It's not until Adora is helping Catra back out of the boat that she realizes how hungry she is. Her stomach growls loud and unhinged. It makes Catra chuckle.

“Hungry?” she asks, tying the boat back to the dock. Adora nods, breathing in deep the smell of the vendors down the road.

“I know the perfect thing," Catra says. They get it from a little shop near the corner of town, two bowls of something that smells so good, Adora almost drowns in her own drool. Catra doesnt let Adora even see it until they’ve found a perfect spot to eat.

They sit down on top of a building on the edge of town. It's old and crumbling. Something tells Adora it's an old watch tower, but maybe that’s just the crossbow sitting on the edge of it talking.

They sit with their legs hanging through the gaps in the railing. The view overlooks the entirety of Half-moon. The castle on one end with the lake on the other, the river flowing right through the center.

Adora all but cries as Catra pops open the bowls and hands one to Adora. Its meat and veggies covered in a mouth watering sauce, Adora is grateful that it's not as hot as the kabab.

Catra chuckles at Adora's pleased hum.

“How’d you become a soldier?” Adora asks, between massive bites of the food. Catra rolls her eyes and hands the blonde a napkin.

“I wanted to protect my people, like my mother did, like my mother's mother did.” Catra leans her chin on her knee and looks at the dark crystals. Some of them slowly glow white for a second before fading. Almost like that myth, stars.

“Half-moon used to be above ground, before the Horde attacked.” she says, her eyes distant. “I was just a kit when it happened but I can still remember the carnage. I don't want to be helpess when something like that happens again.”

Adora eyes the feline with a soft smile. They’re sitting close enough to touch. If Adora wanted to, if she was brave enough, she could brush her thigh against Catra’s. Lean in, kiss her. But that would be weird right? Kiss a girl you just met.

Adora looks up at the sound of bells.

“It's almost midnight,” Catra says, pointing to the belltower. A large clock sits at the top and Adora almost drops her food.

“Holy Hordak, Is that the time? I hope Glimmer had a chase to speak to the princess," Catra turns towards Adora in surprise.

“You didn't figure it out??”

Adora tilts her head, confused. “Figure what out?”

Catra laughs and shakes her head. “Maybe I should reintroduce myself.” Catra stands and brushes off her armor.

“Hello” she sticks out her hand, ”Princess D’rulith of Halfmoon at your service,”

Adora freezes. Looking up into Catra- D’rulith’s mismatched eyes.

“Y-your-?”

“Everyone just calls me Catra.”

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

You give a cat a cookie and she's gonna want you to help her clean out the attic.

Chapter Notes

This is for anyone who really enjoyed that first chapter. I never meant to write another one but about a month ago I was a little inspired. I re read the first chapter and was impressed by my own writing so here goes a try at a second and perhaps a third if you guys enjoy it?

leave a comment and a kudos if you do! they are lifeblood to me. comments are one of the main reasons I post my stories on here.

any feedback about my writing is also welcome!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“You want me to abandon my people, travel to the surface, and fight an intergalactic war lord?” Catra asks, pinching her nose. She leans heavily on the arm of the throne. One leg up and bent.

Adora is blushing, she knows she is. She just spent an entire day semi flirting with the eldest princess of an underground society. A princess who has an endearing accent and gorgeous dual eyes.

“Uh, yes?” Adora winces, ducking her head and bowing just a bit deeper as if it could make up for all the disrespecting she’s done to the Princess already.. Her arm band digs into her skin, the transformed sword warming in her embarrassment. She’s a bit worried she’s about to start glowing.

Only if the Princess doesn’t stop looking at her like that.

“Meirda” Catra whispers under breath, exchanging eye contact with her mother on the throne. Cyra leans back and shrugs, her golden armor glinting with the movement. Nala, next to her, has a large goblet of what smells like coffee resting on her arm rest.

“You’ll come back” Glimmer says, she’s kneeling next to Adora. Her hair was a bit frazzled. They had been apparently looking for Adora for hours after they realized the two teenagers showing them around were royalty and subsequently their older sister was the princess. “It’s just a quick trip into space-”

Catra starts to laugh. “A quick trip into space? You want me to go to space now?”

“And it probably won’t be quick,” Bow murmurs to Glimmer. Adora is not sure Catra picked that up but with the feline’s superior hearing she doesn’t doubt she could.

“We’re all gonna go so it won’t just be you” Adora placades, gesturing to herself and her friends. She blushes, the thought that she could persuade Catra to join the alliance by offering herself up, flooding her mind.

Not in that nefarious way of course. But she and Catra bonded a bit. A lot. Adora really enjoyed herself actually. They could do more of that. Above ground. Fighting on the same side.

Adora ducks her head at the thought. Her idea of a second- first date was fighting in an intergalactic war. The Horde really did a number on her.

“It might be fun!” The Queen says from the throne. She smiles at Catra and allows the girl to lean into her side. Catra’s ears lower and she looks at her mother almost pleadingly. A ‘please don't make me go’ written in the pout on her lip.

“You barely let me scout the surface and now you want me to shoot off into space?”

“It’s more of a relaxed upward angle, not straight up” Bow says, slanting his arm a little as if imagining Darla slowly ascending into the sky.

“Well, you need to get out more,” the Queen’s wife, the other queen, says. She raises an eyebrow at Catra. “You spend all your time in the library”

Catra raises her arms as if to say ‘how is that a bad thing?’

“And She-ra will be there! That’s like having a bodyguard” Nala placades, gesturing to the blonde. Adora smiles, straightening.

“Yeah” she says happily. It’s been a while since anyone trusted her to really do anything. These queens who barely know her trust her to take care of their daughter. It makes her feel lighter then she has in ages

“You guys are complete pushovers,” Catra complains, standing from the throne. “Blondie shows up with a big sword and you trust her with my life?”

Adora pouts “you trusted me with your life”

“I trust you not to let me drown” Catra deadpanns, then she throws her hands in the air “and I can swim!”

“You got Catra to get in the water?” Cyra asks, her ears perking up. She glances at her wife with an excited smile. Adora watches the way Catra’s fur stands straight up and she grits her teeth.

“Of course not,” Catra growls, embarrassed. “We just went out in a boat”

“You were in the water!” Nala turns on her throne excitedly. Forgoing any pleasantries with the visiting princesses and looks straight at her daughter in excitement. “It’s been years since you've been in the water”

“I was on the water. Key word; on” Catra’s fur has stuck up permanently. Her tale completely spiked, her claws extending. Her voice is cracking. “Big difference! Big difference!”

The queens are smiling gleefully and Adora doesn’t realize she is too until Bow bumps her shoulder with a knowing look. Adora coughs, schooling her face into what she hopes isn’t barely contained glee.

“You should totally do it, D’rulith” Nala says, gesturing to the three kneeling before the throne. “This girl is a good influence on you”

“She is not!” Catra's hands are fisted at her sides, her tail up and frazzled in seconds. It sends her mothers’ into a laughing fit. Catra frowns, crossing her arms, her foot tapping.

Adora coughs a bit to hide her own laugh but Glimmer and Bow have a harder time. Bow’s face is red and there’s a hand on his stomach as if he’s in pain. Glimmer is just outright laughing all together.

Catra snarls at them all, though Adora thinks that she’s putting on a bit of a show. Her eyes are still shining, a bit happy. Then they glint and Catra’s face relaxes a bit as she gets an idea.

“Fine!” Catra smiles gleefully and turns to the three kneeling before her. A little spark of hope fills Adora’s chest.

“I’ll do it-”

“Yes!” Bow jumps from his kneel and pumps his fist.

“- on one condition” Catra is smiling evilly. Canines glinting. It does something to Adora’s stomach. Heat, low in her body. Catra looks dangerous. Adora’s always been into dangerous people. The queens look at each other nervously, they seem to know what Catra is going to say.

Bow drops back to his kneel. Embarrassed by his outburst.

“You have to drive out the Clones Malvados.” The Queens wince and raise a royal, placading, hand.

“Now, D’rulith”

“We’ll do it!” Adora says, interrupting her majesty. She coughs when she realizes what she did. She really has to get better at not completely disrespecting the royal family. The queen doesn't seem to mind and gestures for Adora to continue with a bowed head. “I- mean. It would be our honor, your royal highness,”

Adora bows her torso and places a fist above her heart like she’s making a promise. Bow and Glimmer shift uncomfortably next to her.

“Adora-” Glimmer hisses, hitting her arm with a hand. “We don’t know what these Clones Malvados are”

“But we need her,” Adora hisses back, shrugging Glimmer's hand from her shoulder. Catra straightens, a quiet little trill leaving her chest at Adora’s words. “if this is how we get her this is what we do”

“So uh” Bow laughs and tries to talk over Adora’s and Glimmer’s disrespect in the war room. “What do you need us to do?”

Catra smiles gleefully, the Queens’ wince.

“Los Clones Malvados are…Horde soldiers. Clones, not the child soldiers. The ones who all look the same.”

“Prime’s clones,” Glimmer says, looking at Adora.

“Easy” Adora says, patting her wrist band subconsciously. “We could get that done today”

Catra laughs, her hands planting on her hips. Her layers of armor glint in the shine of the glowing rocks.“I would like to see you try”

Adora grins and stands. “I could take out more than you,” she taunts.

Catra scoffs, stepping down the steps that lead to the thrones easily. “they are not normal clones, you dummy. These guys are savages. Loco, They are cut off from the mothership. They're crazy”

“So what? That means they're easier to take out!” Adora nods to Glimmer and Bow who are reluctant to confirm. When the clones disconnect from the hive mind they pretty much give up.

“Not these clones” Catra moves into Adora’s space. “These are Clones Malvados” she says, poking a finger into Adroa’s chest. She smiles ruefully up at the blonde, showing off her sharp feline teeth. “These clones were better off being controlled by an evil dictator”

Adora opens her mouth to retaliate, taking a step into Catra’s space and looking down at her with her superior height. Catra’s eyes flitter down and Adora’s follow, landing on Catra’s plump lips when the Queens’ interrupt.

“Unfortunately, Catra is right,” Cyra says, but she’s smiling. Nala has her hands clasped in front of her face. Stars in her eyes.

Catra coughs and springs back. Walking, quickly, back up the steps of the throne room.

Adroa turns back to her friends and sees two looks of confusion. Glimmer raises an eyebrow and Bow gives Adora a thumbs up.

“After the clones were cut off from the Hive mind, they went a little crazy in the mines.. It turned them into savages.” Cyra turns to Nala who tilts her head and shrugs.

“We think it might be something they ate.”

“Or they just went crazy after being separated from their master” Catra says, she crosses her arms where she stands next to her

mothers' thrones. Adora drops back into her kneel. "It won't be easy. They don't think like people anymore."

"Did they ever?" Glimmer asks, sharing a look with Bow.

"They've been terrorizing Half-moon since they appeared. Rallying behind the one they call Hordak" Cyra says, she leans her chin in her hand and looks down at Adora. "Since they started working together we haven't been able to touch them. They've barricaded themselves in the mines."

"This won't be like traipsing into Half-moon," Catra agrees, "this'll be much harder"

"Either way" Adora says, looking up at Catra, her eyes firm and confident. "If it means you'll join us, we'll fight with you. The Princess Alliance has changed in the last 20 years. We want to protect all the people of Etheria."

Catra tilts her head. She appraises Adora silently, Her fur fluffed up just a bit. Adora smiles and Catra looks away. Her mothers behind her chuckle quietly behind her.

"You'll have the full force of two members of the Princess Alliance and one She-ra-" Glimmer lowers her voice and whispers "who's a total dork" Bow laughs and bumps his shoulder into Glimmer's.

Adora frowns at them, a pout on her lips. She feels like she didn't get the joke.

The Queens' glance at each other and then Catra. "Well, D'rulith?"

Catra clears her throat and rests her hands on the hilts of the swords strapped to her waist.

"You have a deal," Catra smiles, puffing out her chest. "We'll be helping you of course, or more like, you'll be helping us."

"The Half-Moon army will be backing you, She-ra" Cyra says, looking down expectantly at the blonde. "We expect you to

protect them as if they are your own”

“Your people are my people” Adora says, bowing her head, “I’ll protect them with my life”

Nala smiles, she holds her wife's hand tightly. “Then let’s hope by the end of the day, Los Clones Malvados are dead and buried!”

Adora smiles brightly, standing with Glimmer and Bow and looking up at the Queens’. Catra is standing next to them, smiling a bit shyly at Adora. Her hands tight on her hips, her stance sure.

Her confidence leaves a bit of heat in Adora’s body, low in her stomach. The eldest princess of Half-Moon is gorgeous. She’s strong, funny. Adora can’t help but think she would be an amazing addition to the Princess Alliance. To the team. To Adora’s team.

Adora’s smile must have been contagious because Catra gives a small smile back. Her tail whips as she appraises Adora.

But now there is a princess of Brightmoon making inappropriate comments.

“So what the hell was that?” Glimmer asks, rushing to keep up with Adora as she leaves the throne room. A guard before her kindly showing them the way to their chambers for the night.

The walls are carved from smooth rock. Every couple feet, where a window should be, is a cavern full of brightly glowing rock. Not unlike the ones that line Half-moons ceiling. Gorgeous portraits line the walls. Of the queens of the royal family. Landscapes of rolling hills and trees that look suspiciously like the ones far above the palace.

“What was what?” Adora asks, watching the guard before them happily flick her tail. She has no doubt that she’s listening. Her ears flicking back at them is anything to go by.

“You, flirting with the Princess of Half-moon” Glimmer whispers, shoving Bow away when he tries to shush Glimmer.

“Don’t scare her off Glimmer! She’s emotionally stunted!” Bow whispers, Ignoring the dirty look Glimmer throws her way and jumping at the nearly concealed snort the guard ahead of them gives.

“I was not flirting!” Adora whispers back, much better then Glimmer or Bow was. “And I'm not emotionally stunted!”

Glimmer rolls her eyes,”you are so emotionally stunted that you don’t even realize you're emotionally stunted.”

“And you were definitely flirting,” Bow says, “you were giving her the eyes and I totally thought she was going to kiss you when she got all up in your space. Finger on your chest” Bow mimes it as if the visual will help.

Maybe it does because Adora is a little shocked. She had thought, just for a second, that Catra was going to kiss her too. She hadn’t realized anyone else could see it.

“I don't know where you princesses come from but where I come from we don’t flirt with our soon to be allies. We don't flirt at all actually.” Adora says, focusing her gaze on the feline before her and trying not to notice that if she wasn’t listening before. She is definitely listening now. “I was just being nice”

“Oh Adora” Glimmer tuts sadly, she pouts exaggeratedly and Adora just knows she’s about to get teased. “I hate to break it to you but if that’s how you treat all your allies then you have been awfully mean to me and Bow.”

“I want to get flirted with,” Bow agrees, peeking over Glimmer’s shoulder. “Am I not pretty enough, Adora?”

“Don't worry Bow, my ally” Glimmer wraps an arm around his torso and leans her head on his shoulder. “I'll flirt with you, if only to maintain our ally ship”

“Of course,” Bow says, wrapping an arm around her shoulders, leaning into her heavily. “We must maintain our delicate truce to

defeat Horde Prime”

“You guys are a bunch of butt heads” Adora rolls her eyes. the soldier as she doesn't even try to hold in her laughter at that. “I was not flirting with the princess of Half-moon, that would be treason or something!”

“It’s not,” the soldier says, turning her head and winking before stopping at a door to fully face Adora.

“It would actually be pretty tame compared to some other courting rituals. People haven’t been that subtle with their affections for our Princess in ages.

Adora’s mouth gapes like a fish. Bow and Glimmer start elbowing each other behind Adora.

“Then again, Our royal highness hasn’t taken a shining like this to anyone.”

Bow and glimmer squeal behind her, clasped hands and all.

“You're supposed to be a biased third party” Adora frowns at the guard, pushing the door open herself.

“I am loyal to her royal highness” the guard says, bowing with a fist over her heart before letting the door close behind Bow and Glimmer.

“Did you hear that?” Glimmer asks Bow, shoving him a little in her excitement. He doesn’t seem to mind, “Adora has a chance!”

“Excuse me?” Adora frowns at them “did I not before?”

“Well-” Bow starts biting his lip a bit “you kind of have that awkward, ‘I just escaped the bunker’ energy.”

“And you kinda did” Glimmer deadpanned walking around the chambers they have been provided. “Except the FrightZone is worse than a bunker but you didn't have to marry an old man.”

“What is a bunker? Marry an old man?”

“Exactly” Bow winces, collapsing into a couch on the far wall. There's a kitchen on the other and beyond that a hallway with three doors. Glimmer opens the fridge, pleasantly surprised to find it stocked with fruit,

“But for some reason, your flirting is kinda good,” Glimmer says, taking a bite of a fruit that looks like an apple but squishes like a peach. “For someone who just escaped the bunker.”

“Yeah” Bow agrees, “she even got the princess to spend the entire day with her within the first hour”

“How did you do it, Adora? Did you use She-ra?”

“What- no!” Adora glares at them, her heart sinking a the idea that Catra is invested in She-ra no Adora.

“We would have noticed if Catra was just into the beef cake” Bow says, tapping his chin and smiling when Glimmer comes to sit down next to him. “It looked like she was into Adora’s personality? Or something?”

“Yeah- Adora must have been showing off her battle strategy or-” Glimmer hands half of the fruit and Bw takes it happily.

“I am right here!”

“Or she was just satisfied with Adora’s muscles.”

“She was impressed by She-ra but Adora is what really drove the infatuation home” Glimmer agrees, “I think that’s adorable”

“Adora-ble” Bow laughs,

“I'm going to bed!” Adora throws her hands in the air and glares at them, “maybe try to get some sleep instead of making out on that couch” she says, smiling when Bow chokes on his fruit and Glimmer turns a bright red,

“We are not going to make out-” Adora closes the door of the first room before they can finish defending themselves, leaning against the wall a little out of breath.

As much as she hates their teasing, they’re right. Catra hadn’t been talking to She-ra that whole time. She had been talking to Adora. Unlike the other princesses, Mermista, Perfuma. Catra had liked Adora.

The thought leaves her feeling happy. Very happy. Giddy almost. She can barely contain her smile as she shucks off her compressions shirt and pants, her boots left at the door.

Catra had liked Adora, had spoken to Adora, had shard food and a boat with Adora. She had been impressed with She-ra's strength and Adora’s ability to wield her, but she had poked her finger into Adora’s chest, not She-ra’s.

Adora can barely close her eyes.

The Caravan is ready by morning. More importantly the blockade is nearly set up by the time Adora gets out of the bed she was given. It’s soft, too soft and Adora hadn’t been able to sleep much in it. Unlike Brightmoon, Halfmoon was nearly silent. No chirping crickets or frogs. No water falls thundering across the castle.

Bow and Glimmer are gone when she wakes up, their bedrooms empty. If they had even bothered to separate for the night. There’s a bowl of sliced fruit on the kitchen table, which Adora eats. Then she sets off to find Catra.

The palace and the city are alive today. It’s still early but when Adora finally finds Glimmer and Bow they’re nearly done helping the townsfolk put up a barricade. Neither Bow or Glimmer know the plan, just that the Queens’ and princess D’rulith ordered the construction of a sturdy wall.

It faces the one of the many hole littered walls of cavern Half moon residing in, though most of these are blocked off with

collapsed rubble and metal plating. Do not enter, written in multiple languages, cover every available surface.

It reminds her of an ant hole or a bunny den. Half-moon is the burrow with many exits and entrances. A maze of tunnels that connects them to the outside world.

These must be the mines the Queen’s spoke of. Beyond them must be the stronghold of the Clones Malvados.

Adora finds Catra in the heart of the commotion, she’s huddled around a table with multiple other generals. All of them are covered in Magicat armor and weapons. The red mask rests against the top of her head. The skull of the dead animal looming over her.

She looks scary, she looks strong. It has nothing to do with how fast Adora’s heart is beating.

In all her time recruiting Princesses for the Alliance, which hasn't been a very long time, Adora has never met anyone like her. She shines on the battlefield, she directs her generals with a sure hand.

She taps the edge of the map and looks up at her Generals, finally noticing Adora’s blatant staring. A few generals around her cough and hide smiles and Catra locks eyes with Adora and stops talking.

“Adora, you’re here. Where are the Brightmoon delegates?” Catra asks, straightening and playing with the handle of one of the swords on her hip.

“Glimmer and Bow are helping set up the last of the blockades. They’ll be on their way here, shortly.” Adora says, straightening and joining the Half-moon generals at the table. She tries to meet the height of the war-hardened men and women before her but she can’t have succeeded. She’s dressed in a Horde compression shirt and pants. Catra nods all the same and turns to her commanders.

“Alright, you know your stations and your responsibilities.” the general nods, their fists flying over their hearts as they bow their heads at their princess. “In less than an hour we’ll be under siege. Half-Moon is depending on you to hold the barricade”

The generals pound their fists against their chests and nod their heads. Catra stands straight and nods in return, her fist on her own chest.

“Dismissed”

They turn and leave the hut, heading back to their soldiers. Adora watches them go, not noticing the way Catra watches her.

“With any luck, our plan doesn't work and nothing happens. you lot can run off and save the world” Catra sighs, trying for a joke but it falls a bit flat. Adora smiles anyway.

“You really don’t want to go to space huh?” she asks, watching Catra re-set her map and her tiny metal soldiers, smoothing out the wrinkles on its surface.

“I don’t want to leave my people, we’ve been through enough as it is.” Catra admits, looking up at the real soldiers helping raise the barricade. “If we expose that the Magicats live, we could become a target, again.”

“If we defeat Prime, your people will be safe for a milenia.” Adora takes a step towards her, watching Catra’s ears twitch. “You could live in the sun again.”

“Or they could all die in the fight.” Catra says, looking at Adora from beneath her eyelashes. “War is messy and death comes easy. My people were nearly eradicated from this very fight twenty years ago.”

Adora sits in a bit of silence. Watching as Catra consciously relaxes her shoulders. She places her hands on her hip and plays with the hilt of her sword in a nervous tick.

“I know that joining the Princess Alliance doesn’t necessarily mean Prime will find my people but it puts them at a risk I don't know if they’re ready for. If they die because of me-” Catra’s voice breaks and she looks back at Adora with a set jaw. “I would never forgive myself.. I couldn’t live with it”

Adora straightens, thumbing her gauntlet of protection.

“I meant what I said. Your people are my people. I’ll protect them with my life. Even after this is over” Adora gestures to the cave entrance. Catra looks up a bit surprised. Her eyes flitting over Adora’s features. “You won’t be the only Champion protecting Half-Moon. Not anymore.” Catra’s blushing in a way only a magicat can. Fluffed fur and tilting ears.

“That’s a lot of people to protect.” Catra looks away and runs a hand through her hair, smoothing it over. “Aren't you worried you’ll neglect your own family”

“I don’t have any,” Adora admits. “Horde soldier born and raised. I never knew them. I have friends, but they are pretty good at protecting themselves” Adora gestures behind her, wincing when she looks to see Bow showing off his magnifying glass arrow to a confused soldier.

“Even if their not very good at showing it”

“Well then” Catra relaxes and nods, turning back to her map. Adora looks up at her. “You have family now, Adora. Half-moon would love to have you.”

Adora smiles, her eyes sting just a bit.

“And to have a place to stay after this shit show is over.” Catra clears her throat, “The war I mean.” Catra looks up into Adora’s shiny eyes before immediately looking away and gesturing to the caves before them “this is only the beginning.”

“It would be an honor” Adora says, her voice quiet.

Catra shrugs, refusing to look Adora in the eye. “Yeah, well. We could always use another set of hands to wrangle those mangy orphans.”

“Adora!” Glimmer interrupts, ducking into the tent. “Did you find her? We need to -” Glimmer’s eyebrows raise at Adora and Catra’s closeness. Adora really hadn’t noticed stepping in Catra’s space, too focused on the sweet words the feline was saying.

“Start planning?” Catra finishes, raising an eyebrow. Bow ducks in after Glimmer and nods.

“Yes, actually. None of us know the plan” Bow gestures to the barricades. “Are we not going in after the clones?”

“No” Catra agrees, gesturing for them to huddle around the map. Adora steps up next to Catra. Her arm pressing into the feline's warm side. Catra swallows and continues.

“Los Malvados have set up a stronghold in this cavern” Catra points at the map beyond a maze of tunnels. It’s large but not nearly as large as the cave Half-moon resides in. Adora tilts her head, tracing the various caves and wondering which one they’ll be taking.

“You” she points at Glimmer ”are going to teleport in, plant a bomb and set the timer before getting the hell out of there”

Glimmer’s eyebrows draw together and Adora looks up at Catra. “bring the Malvado to us”

“Exactly,” Catra agrees, smiling up at Adora. “Those little shits can’t swim so” Catra gestures before them at the blockade. Only then does Adora realize it’s more of a funnel.

“We are going to sit and wait for them to come to us. They'll panic, fall into the river and drown. We take out the stragglers. Keep them from reaching Half-moon.

“You don’t really need She-ra at all” Adora says, pouting. She doesn’t want to admit it but she feels a wash of relief. She’s done so much fixing and saving lately that a weekend relaxing in a place like Half-moon with a beautiful girl like Catra is just what she needs.

“No,” Catra laughs, placing a hand on Adora’s forearm and over the gauntlet. She draws her eyebrows together when her fingers touch the metal. Adora raises her eyebrows a bit at the surge of bright magic that rushes through her. “We’ll still keep you around just in case. You never know when a eight foot warrior might come in handy”

Adora grins, puffing out her chest a little at the indirect praise.

“I can’t teleport that far.” Glimmer interrupts. Her eyes glued to the map. She points to the distance between them and the stronghold.

“What?” Catra asks, looking away from Adora, her hand dropping from the gauntlet of protection.

“I’m nearly out of teleports” Glimmer says, looking up at Catra. Glimmer seems a bit embarrassed and she scratches at the back of her neck.

“You can run out?” Catra asks like this is ridiculous. Glimmer frowns, and throws her hands in the air.

“It doesn't work like that! More like I'm out of stored magic. I would have to go home and stock up before attempting this jump. Especially if you want me to make it back”

“You have to recharge your magic?

Glimmer blushes, embarrassed. “Yes”

“We’ll just have to get her closer” Adora says, gesturing to the maze of mines and tunnels. “Can anyone navigate this maze?”

Catra bites her lip and presses her fingers into her temples. “Yes, I can.” Adora watches her tail flip back and forth in through, it brushes up the back of Adora’s leg and the Blonde jerks just a bit at the sensation.

“Alright,” Catra sighs. “This is what we'll do. Me and Glimmer will go-”

She’s interrupted as soon as she starts. Surprisingly it’s Bow who raises his hand “We’re not letting you guys walk into the heart of the enemy alone,” Adora nods in Agreement.

“It'll be easier with just two” Catra argues, “quieter, smaller, quicker”

“Not if your ambushed” Adora says, “then your waddling ducks”

Catra, confused by that argument, blinks. “ We’ll be dead no matter how many we bring if we’re ambushed”

Adora raises an eyebrow and tapps her gauntlet. “Not if you have She-ra”

Catra turns to Adora. “Cocky about your abilities are we?”

“Yes” Adora nods, watching as Catra rolls her eyes heavily and then plants her face in her hands. The mask atop her head slips just a bit and Adora reaches to straighten it.

Catra freezes, flushes, and growls to herself. She claps her hands and looks up at the three Rebellion members.

“Alright a small force of us will get closer to the encampment. Right on the outskirts.” Catra points at a spot on the map and looks up at Glimmer. “Is this close enough?”

“Yes” Glimmer says, her cheeks flushed.

“But after the bomb is placed.” Catra straightens, and makes eye contact with them each separately. “everyone in the attack force

has to get to higher ground, the malvado will panic and scatter. It'll be a stampede. Anyone in the way-”

“Will get crushed” Adora finishes.

“Exactly.” Catra points to her and nods.

“This is going to be very difficult,” Bow murmurs, eyes on the map of the maze of tunnels.

“Yes” Catra agrees like that was a stupidly obvious statement. “but we do it right and everyone comes home”

“And then we go to space” Adora grins smugly at Catra. The feline rolls her eyes.

“Yes, yes, space. Whatever you want.”

Glimmer looks at Adora with raised eyebrows, Bow isn't doing much better, hiding his smile behind clasped hands and pretending to be absorbed in the map.

“Well-” Catra eyes both of Adora’s friends weirdly, reaching beneath the table and pulling out a bundle of fabric. “Here- It’s cold down here, I don't know how you havent gotten hyperthermia yet”

Catra looks away as if embarrassed, straightening her already straight mask. Adora unfurls the fabric to see a coat. A leather jacket. It’s far more Catra’s style then it is Adora’s, metal clasps and a bright red zipper.

“I don’t get cold all that easily” Adora murmurs, rubbing her thumb over the soft leather. Catra clears her throat and reaches as if to take it back.

“No, no!” Adora says a bit too loud, startling Catra to look back at her. “I love it, I’m wearing it” she slides her arms through the arm holds and nearly shivers at the soft flannel lining against her skin.

Catra smiles just a bit as Adora adjusts and reaches up to untuck the collar where it got stuck. Adora flushes, watching Catra's dual eyes flit across her face. Down her cheeks, across her lips and finally up to Adora's eyes. Catra clears her throat.

"Pretty- Yeah- it's also pretty sturdy so think of it as armor"

"Nice save" Glimmer scoffs, making Catra jump a bit before she sneers at her.

The group that enters the cave is small. Catra added a handful of Magicat's just in case she lost the Bright moon delegates and they needed a guide out. It consists of Catra, Adora. Glimmer Bow. a few Brightmoon guards.

Catra leaves her personal guards under strict orders to protect Half-moon with their lives. To kill any clone they see and to protect each other. It sounded almost like a chant. Like prayer that'll protect them.

The generals looked at Catra as if she was a Queen. The real Queens behind the Barricade, helping the few families just behind it evacuate in case the worst came to worst.

Adora waits for Catra at the entrance of the tunnel. She watches the feline grasp one of her generals arms in a firm handshake. He smiles and pats Catra on the shoulder, whispering in her ear before letting Catra go to jog towards the entrance of the tunnel.

"Who is that?" she asks, as she pulls Catra up the ledge and into the dark. The feline's hand lingers in hers for just a moment longer than necessary before pulling back. Adora blushes and thanks the darkness for hiding it.

"An old friend," Catra says, resting her hands on her hips at the handles of her swords and gestures with her head for the party to start walking. The Half-moon guards nod and lead the way. "He taught me to use a staff"

“Oh” Adora nods, walking alongside Catra, watching Bow and Glimmer as they stumble in the darkness. They are both holding dull, glowing sticks. They're covered in a cave wax that glows in complete darkness. “You always remember the one who teaches you how to fight with a staff”

“Who taught you?” Catra asks, glancing at her.

Adora chokes, without realizing it she had been thinking about Shadow Weaver. The woman who raised her, abused her.

“Oh-” Adora waves the question away, watching Catra’s eyebrows furrow. “You know, Fright Zone trainee’s. We were usually taught by older cadets actually” it’s followed by a false laugh but Catra doesn’t call her on her rambled lie. She instead pierces her with her sharp gaze and shrugs.

“I wasn’t supposed to learn, my mothers’ forbid it.” Catra says, looking away. Adora is thankful for the reprieve. “I think they thought if I never learned to fight I would never need to. I knew better, even as a kid”

“But you don’t want to leave to join the fight? Knowing that eventually you won't have a choice?” Adora asks, she watches as Catra sets her jaw.

“The rebellion was losing, drawing attention to myself would only put Half-moon at risk”

It’s a statement that isn’t open to debate, and Adora doesn’t know what she would say to that so she lets it be. Instead she subtly brushes the back of her hand against Catra’s and pretends not to notice when the feline glances at her.

They wander through the tunnels following the Magicat guards and their superior sense of direction, eyesight, smell. It doesn’t take long before they reach their first stopping point. Adora learns that Magicat’s walk quickly and take the shortest route.

Adora is surprised when they set up a fire. The guards' packs were full of logs and fire starters and they didn't hesitate to get to work. Adora winces with every strike and loud noise and doesn’t notice when Catra leaves her side to help.

Adora slumps down against the cave wall across from Bow and Glimmer, eyes on the growing flame. Catra sits down next to her as the drums start and Adora jumps, hard. Knocking her head against the wall. Bow and Glimmer have a similar response, their hands clasping over their mouths.

“Aren't you scared they'll hear us?” Adora asks, grabbing Catra’s arm. The feline smiles placatingly.

“That's the point” Catra says, gesturing to the drums and the crackling fire.”They knew we were here the minute we stepped into the cavern but the Malvado are scared of loud noise. We think it’s similar to a rabies victim and water”

Adora tilts her head and watches the Half-moon guards bang their drums. “So the guards are distractions?”

“In a way. The echo will confuse the clones. They'll be too scared of the noise to risk wandering into the tunnels. As soon as the bomb goes off the guards will scatter and allow the clones to stampede. There’s enough of them that as long as each human has a guard to follow, you won’t get lost on the way out.”

“Kinda genius,” Adora mutters.

“Yeah, but I'm just worried we won't make it out in time to avoid being deafened and get trampled.” Catra admits, she eyes the length of tunnel they hiked down. It was nearly an hour's walk. Maybe two. It would take a while to sprint to safety if they couldn't find higher ground to hide in.

Adora makes a mental note to stick very close to Catra. For safety.

Adora’s head jerks up “wait- deafened?”

“Did you think we were setting off a real bomb/” Catra asks, chuckling. “Underground?”

Adora shrugs, a blush dusting her cheeks. She was imagining a real bomb. One big enough and an explosion loud enough to send the clones running. Adora spins the gauntlet on her arm.

“Adora” Catra laughs and Adora decides she really likes the way Catra says her name. Even if it’s in a teasing way. “that would end with all the rock above us coming down on our heads.”

Adora looks up at the stone and shoves Catra a little with her shoulder.

“The bomb is a flash bang. It flashes and then bangs.”

Adora rolls her eyes .”I know what a flash bang is”

Catra raises an eyebrow “I was just making sure”

Adora shivers in the darkness of the cave. The jacket had been a good call. Even with her magical body heat she’s cold. She tightens her arms around herself just a bit.

Catra notices, she doesn't hesitate to pull the fur from her shoulders and drapes in over the blonde, coving her up. It’s unreasonably warm and Adora looks gratefully up at her.

“Thanks,” she says quietly. Catra looks embarrassed for a moment. As if being nice is something bad.

“Yeah, well I have fur and you don’t so-”

Adora smiles smugly and Catra scoffs, sitting back against the stone wall. Adora grins into the fire, watching Bow and Glimmer huddle together close to the flame.

“Can I ask you a question?” Catra asks, she’s tapping her dual swords with her thumbs her shoulder leaning slightly into Adora’s.

Adora shrugs, “you just did”

“Smart ass” Catra whispers, frowning at her as Adora smiles. Adora gestures for her to go on.

“Why do you limit your powers like that?” Catra asks, she gestures to the sword in Adora’s hands.

“What?” Adora asks, looking down at her weapon.

Catra leans back and points, “your sword, you use it to turn into She-ra. Why?”

Adora laughs, shaking her head not fully understanding one bit. “The sword gives me my powers, it is how I become she-ra

“No” Catra raises an eyebrow and looks at Adora confused.

“No?” Adora repeats, also confused.

Catra nods, resolutely, “no, it doesn't”

“Yes, it does” Adora turns it into a bracelet and hands it to Catra. “Here. look. Without it I’m basically useless”

The drumming cut’s off dramatically. All at once. Adora jerks up confused. Adora notices all the half moon residents going quiet.

Catra hesitantly takes the bracelet as Adora is distracted by her friends' faces. Glimmer and Bow are nearly crying in shock. Or maybe glee. There is no way Catra is going to go into space now that Bow and Glimmer have completely disrespected her people. Adora doesn’t know what they did but it was enough to get the guards to stop playing their drums.

Catra laughs, flabbergasted. holding the bracelet in her hand in shock before looking back up at Adora.

Adora opens her mouth to say something, anything, but she’s thoroughly caught off guard with everyone else’s reactions that

she doesn’t know what to say.

Catra grins “Yes”

“What?” Adora asks,

“It would be my honor to mary you, Adora”

“ I- what?” Adora croaks, she’s red as a tomato.

Someone yelps and Catra is on her feet, hands going to her swords as another guard shouts.

“Malvados!”

Something hits and tackles Catra to the floor. Adora is after them in a second. The monster is green and snarling. Viscous lumpy fluid leaks from its mouth in a sickly neon green. It drools over Catra as Adora grasps in around what should be its waist and heaves it off of her.

She isn’t much help, she’s soon overpowered by her own assailant. A replica of the one wrapped in her arms. This one instead knocks her over the head with what must be a club.

Adora grunts and falls to her knees, the clone that attacked Catra still wriggling in her arms. Trying to get free.

“Adora” Catra reaches for her but there’s no use. There’s so many of the green monsters, they were caught off guard. They were overwhelmed in seconds.

Adora’s eyes draw to the light glow coming from the ears of the thing that tackled her before the world goes dark.

There's a bag over Adora’s head. She’s reminded of just yesterday when she was in the exact same position. This time instead of walking to Half-Moon and being held prisoner in the Queens’ throne room. Adora was dragged along the bumpy surface of a cave. Her hands and feet, bound in rope.

She’s even more grateful for the jacket now, keeping the jagged rocks from tearing up the worst of her back. She doesn’t know where they took her but where she is not protected by the jacket is raw and stinging. No doubt impeded with stones and Etheria knows what.

Catra is leaning into her shoulder. She still has Adora’s sword wrapped around her wrist. Or at least Adora hopes she does. She can feel the warm magic close so the Sword of Protecting hadn’t gone far. This time there's a bag over Catra’s head too.

And Glimmers, and Bows. If their groaning is anything to go by.

“This sucks,” Adora says, turning towards Catra. “Two bags in as many days? Talk about bad luck”

Catra chuckles. “Sorry about the first bag, that was a precaution,”

“Yeah, yeah, I get it. Being Horde scum and all”

Catra hums and tilts her head. “Naw, you not horde scum. Your rebellion scum. Soon to be Half-moon scum”

Adora coughs, a warm feeling in her chest even if her and Catra are prisoners and probably soon to be dead. Catra could just be referring to her offer to let Adora stay after the war. Or she could be referring to the mention of marriage just before their attack.

“Excuse me” Bow interrupts, “how did the clones even get past the noise? I thought they were scared of it”

“My guess?” Catra hums, “they stuffed their ears with glowing jelly. Anyone else notice the slight orange glow from their heads?”

“Or they took their chance when Adora fucking proposed” Glimmer complains, there’s a thunk and Adora assumes Glimmer is smacking her head against the wall.

“yeah so- tell me about that?” Adora asks hesitantly, turning to Catra. Or where she assumes Catra is. The feline laughs and

playfully knocks their shoulders together.

“You proposed! Not me!” Catra says, she playfully drags a tail of Adora’s side. “How did you make it all the way to Half-moon without learning any of our customs?” she laughs. Adora knows it’s teasing but she feels overwhelmed and embarrassed.

If she thought she had a chance with Catra before? There is absolutely no way now.

“What did I do?” Adora asks, her voice must sound sufficiently pitiful because Catra lets up. Keeping her tale to herself but can’t quite get rid of the teasing tone of her voice.

“You gave me a bracelet. that’s a proposal where I came from”

“Even if it was kind of an accident?” Adora asks, covered in embarrassment. Catra laughs,

“Kind of?” she teases, “Yes, when one propose’s there is no ‘take backs’ at least not in my culture” Adora winces, but then thinks that being tied to Catra forever wouldn't be so bad. A place to belong and no one can say anything about it.

And then she scolds herself because that is a crazy thought.

“Well, alright then” Adora nods, “is it ok if a horse is my best man?” she asks, trying to make a joke.

Catra laughs, leaning heavily into Adora’s side. Adora can’t help but smile along. Feeling warm fur against her arm.

“Is that a no?”

“You're sweet you know that?” Catra asks, it's so soft that Adora blushes. Her neck is probably red.

“I- well-”

“You're the Princess of Power, I'm the Princess of Half-moon, I'm sure we can explain that it was a misunderstanding” Catra placades.

“And disrespect the Queens of Brightmoon and their culture” Adora freezes up, her hands tightening in fists where they are tied behind her back. “I can't do that!”

Catra laughs harder. “Adora” she giggles ,”you don’t want to marry me”

“Says who?” Adora asks, Catra goes quiet. Adora can imagine her looking at her in confusion.

“Adora, we met yesterday. You barely know me”

“Well, now I'll have tons of time to get to know you,” Adora says, shrugging.

Catra laughs and shakes her head, “let’s see if we survive this and then talk about our impending marriage”

“Stop laughing, Bow. you're interrupting their flirting” there’s a thunk and then a yelp and Adora can almost see the punch Glimmer gave the archer.

Catra relaxes back against Adora, her tail curling around the blonde’s list. They listen to Glimmer and Bow bicker a bit before their peace is interrupted.

“What did you mean before, about Adora’s sword. “ Glimmer asks, she turns her head to where she thinks Catra is.

“I meant what I said” Catra says, confused

“Yeah, what did you mean?” Adora asks. Catra shifts, seemingly a bit uncomfortable. How she can be perfectly fine discussing their marriage but not towards this, Adora doesn’t know.

“You're using that sword like a power limiter,” Catra says with a shrug Adora can feel. “you'd be way better off without it”

Adora shakes her head. “The sword is what lets me turn into She-ra” .

Catra scoffs, her head tilting. “No, it doesn't” she says, turning towards the blonde.

“Yes- it”

“Adora” Cara says exasperated. “You are She-ra”

“Yes, I know that-”

“You’re She-ra” She says again. Quicker as if that will help.

Yes-

“Not the sword” Catra gestures best she can with hands bound in front of her.

“Of course I'm not a sword,” Adora tilts her head, confused.

“The sword is like a crutch. From what I've seen, you say your magic words and wave your little helping stick around to get the magic flowing.”

“What?” Adora asks,

“Here watch” there's a ripping sound and then the bag is being gently taken off Adora’s head. She winces as the bag drags across the cut on her temple. Catra smiles in apology.

The ropes are cut and laying at Catra’s knees.

“You could get out this entire time?” Glimmer asks, outraged. Listening to Catra moves around the dingy cell. The floor is covered in what looks like blood. The walls are shaking and now Adora can hear what must be distant cheering.

“Claws” Catra says, she turns back to Adora and grabs the bracelet on her wrist. Thank the stars Catra still had it.

“I’ll put it in terms you can understand” Catra unclasps it. “This is like the key to a skiff” Adora draws her eyebrows together. The metaphor makes a bit of sense even if it doesn't. “It makes it easier but you don’t really need it. You can hotwire. Or you can just make it so you don’t need keys at all.”

“Catra- what-”

“Really the keys make it more difficult because if you depend on them you can’t start your car at all” Catra holds the bracelet up. “And if anyone else gets their hands on them? They can take your skiff”

Catra concentrates and Adora feels a tug low in her stomach. It isn’t uncomfortable but strange. Like someone else is poking at her.

“Ah-”

Adora is enveloped in a bit of magic. Not her own. This magic is red and fiery. This is Catra.

The bracelet turns into a cup. Catra raises an eyebrow. Adora feels another tug, grunts, and the cup turns into a key.

Oh my god” Adora murmurs, watching Catra click the key into the magic gauntlets at Glimmer's hand. “You just hijacked me”

“No,” Catra says, looking up at her. “I have the key, therefore I can drive your skiff. Sure I have to know how to drive but I have the key so I can pretty much do what I want with it.”

“Can you turn into She-ra?” Adora asks, the cuffs holding Glimmer together fall to the floor and the girl hurries to rip the bag off.

“No” Catra laughs, reaching over to cut the rope bindings on Bow’s hands and then Adora’s.

“I don’t have the physiology for that. That’s all you”

“All me?” Adora asks, Catra tilts her head. “Adora, you are She-ra. It’s your magic. Even if you're handicapping yourself with the sword, the sword needs you to work. Not the other way around.”

“Oh my god” Glitter says, watching as Catra turns the key back into a bracelet and sets it back in Adora’s hands. “Your a witch”

Catra looks up, offended. “I'm a magicat. MAGi-CAT. Curse the moon's, you lot are slow”

Glimmer gaps her mouth like a fish.

“What are you still doing here?” Catra asks, gesturing to Glimmer. “Go plant the bomb, we really can’t get any closer. We’re inside the compound.

“What?” Bow squeaks. Ripping the bag of his own head.

“Shit” Glimmer says, pulling her rucksack off her shoulders and looking inside to make sure she still has the flash bang. She sighs and holds it up, dropping the bag.

“Alright” she says, pointing to Catra and then Bow and then Adora. “I'll be right back, don't go anywhere. We’re close enough that I think I can plant the bomb and get all of us far enough away”

Bow and Adora make eye contact. Neither of them like that idea. Catra shrugs and gestures to the door of the prison.

“We don’t have much of a choice, Sparkles.”

Glimmer’s eyes widen at the approaching guard and she growls at Catra.

“It’s Glimmer,” she teleports away in a shower of sparkles that has Catra sneezing.

“Aw” Bow says, even as he edges away from the door and the clone with the key. “That was such a cute sneeze.”

“I am not cute,” Catra growls. The clone opens the cage and Catra launches at them. Her hand finding the hole in the back of the clone's neck. The thing drops, the green sludge spewing from its mouth.

There’s another one just behind it and Adora stumbles to her feet to help but it’s no use. The guard stabs Catra with a stun baton and then waves it threateningly at Adora. Adora glances down at the bracelet in her hands and calls for the sword.

Nothing happens.

Adora’s eyes widen and she tries again but the familiar pull of magic dissipates and the clone sticks the stun baton into her gut. Adora drops and is helpless to stop it when it heads for Bow.

Bow puts up quite a fight but is shoved to the floor by another pair of hands.

“Fresh meat” another pair of hands grabs Adora. the clone growls, it’s hunched and still leaking green from its mouth as it hauls Adora over it’s shoulders. “I love fresh meat”

Adora is dragged through the cave, the walls still shake here and the cheering and jeering only gets louder. her legs still twitching from the force of the electricity. She can hear Catra struggle and growl behind her.

Adpra tries to turn her head but she is forcibly faced forwards by two Clone hands. The tunnel opens into a bright cavern nearly a quarter of Half-moons.

This is more like a bowl, the walls are lined with stairs, stands. They're covered in clones. Identical bodies with green foaming mouths jeer and shove each other in the makeshift stones stands. They’re clones but less uniform. Disconnected from the hive mind they’ve resorted to savages. Foaming at the mouth.

Adora struggles as the clones drag her towards the ring. Her teeth digging into the wet, red sand. There's a drop of about six feet and Adora is shoved in, her legs collapsing beneath her she lands face first into the sand.

It’s blood. That’s why the sand is so wet and red. Its covered in blood. Metallic and stinging Adora holds back a gag as she spits as much as she can out. It’s still gritty between her teeth.

The drop must have been so no one can climb out. The walls are too steep and too slick. There are no foot holds that Adora can see as she stumbles to her feet.

Adora!” Catra shouts, peering over the side of the drop before she’s dragged back by four identical hands. One of which clamps over her mouth.

Adora, confused and bleary, looks down at the bracelet clasped in her grip, begging it to turn into a sword. Into a rope into anything but a bracelet.

The clones yelling get’s louder and more uniform as a clone on the far side of the ring stands. He looks like the others but he is draped in furs and cloth. Instead of a uniform stand like the rest and has a throne behind him, made of what must be animal bones and mucus.

“Quiet my brothers!” he shouts, more coherent than the rest of the clones. “We will soon have our show! What a show it will be with this fresh meat!”

“Fresh meat!” the clones chant, “fresh meat! fresh meat!”

Adora looks back at Catra, the fear must show clear in her eyes because the feline digs her canines into the clone's hand, letting it whip away with a yelp. She kicks the other in the stomach before rushing to the edge of the pit.

She doesn’t make it very far before she’s held down by the shoulders. Her front is forced into the ground.

“Adora” Catra yells, the growling clones at the edge of the ring forcing her back to her knees. . “Believe in yourself or some shit! It’s in you! Do it quickly!”

Adora laughs, self-deprecatingly, shaking her bracelet and begging Mara to help her. Catra was nearly no help. If anything it’s her fault Adora is doubting herself. Though the feeling of Catra’s magic touching hers as she directs the sword warms her stomach just a bit.

The clones all around the ring cheer and jear. Adora looks up and sees the leader clone scream from his throne, globs of green goo dripping from his mouth, he’s covered in fur and bone. The clones around him push for his attention.

He lords over the stone railing before him and points down. The cavern below him, a large tunnel covered in claw marks, growls,

A hulkiing form crawls into the crystal light. Flinching at the flickering torches that line the ring. It’s huge, covered in fur and blood and scars. Massive teeth and two glowing green eyes. Some kind of beast the clones have tracked down.

Adora is shaking. She’s confused at first. Looking down at her hands where they hold her bracelet in an iron grip. She’s never trembled like this before. But she has also never faced a foe so large without a weapon.

The mighty She-ra, protector of Etheria, is trembling like a child.

Her magic is farther than ever, mysteriously shut off by a gorgeous princess who's looking at Adora in what could only be an apology. Catra bites her lip and raises an eyebrow, jerking her head and glancing down at the bracelet.

Adora shrugs her shoulders. It’s useless now. Just like she is. She can’t even turn the thing back into a sword.

The monster before her growls, feeding on the roaring and jeering of the cloned crowd. It shakes its ginormous hide, eyes locked on

Adora’s form. They must be starving it because even Adora can hear the grumble of its stomach as they smell what must be blood on Adora temple.

A commotion in the stands draws Adora’s gaze back to Catra. Glimmer has reappeared in a shower of sparkles, breathless and stumbling just a bit as she tackled one of the guards holding the Princess of Half-moon down.

Catra sneezes but doesn’t hesitate to take her chance. Kicking the other clone in the stomach, ripping her arms from his hold and shoving her hand into the port on the back of his neck.

“Glitter!” she shouts, shoving the twitching clone into the pit and ducking as the next tries to tackle her. It stumbles over the edge and lands head first, its neck cracking unnervingly.

“Get Arrow boy and get out!”

“What? Where’s Adora?!” Glimmer shouts back. Helping Bow as he struggles, held against the far wall by two clones. “We can’t leave without her!”

“I've got her!” Catra yells back, her eyes flitting to the hulking monster as it starts taking large thunder steps towards Adora. “You get Bow and go!”

Glimmer grits her teeth, her eyes following Catra’s and her mouth dropping at the monster she finds there. “Oh my stars” she says, looking over the lip of the pit at Adora.

“I have her,” Catra snarls. Shoving Glimmer towards Bow. “leave!” she doesn’t stop to watch Glimmer disappear in a shimmer of sparkles. She’s jumping into the pit and landing delicately on her feet before she’s sprinting for Adora. Unfortunately, her dual swords have been ripped from her hips at some point, leaving her defenseless.

Her frantic running is what urges the beast into action. Drawing its attention away from Adora. The thing roars and tenses its

hindlegs. Adora has seen that movie a thousand times before in rats before the lung to bite you.

“Catra!” Adora shouts, turning away from the creature and dropping her useless bracelet. Catra is much faster than Adora, meeting the blonde in the middle. Adora is much stronger then Catra though, forcing the feline down with a grunt and covering Catra with her body.

The monster lunges.

Catra grips her hands in Adora’s jacket and Adora gasps. Red and fiery magic floods into her. Adora glows like she has a thousand times before but instead of her golden light it’s flooded in bright red. This must be what Catra meant when she said hot wire.

She grunts again as the monster lands. It’s claws digging into She-ra’s back but coming no closer to scratching her. The leather jacket has stayed in the transformation. Deflecting the claws as if it was made of metal. Catra really wasn’t wrong when she told Adora to think of it as armor.

She-Ra's form flickers just a bit as Catra's flood of magic slows to a trickle but then Adora realize’s why. She’s no longer huddled over Catra’s feline-like body. She’s huddled over a feline. Period.

It growls as it slithers from Adora’s grasp. Turning towards the monster still attached to Adora’s back. Dual eyes lock on Adora as if to ask ‘what are you waiting for?’ She-ra, flickering but still there, doesn't hesitate to twist and grab the thing around the neck. Throwing it forward and away from them.

The beast doesn’t have time to twist onto its back before Catra is on it, her jaws clamp around its neck but her body jerks, blood squelches and Catra lets go with a yowl. The monster rolls back onto its feet, snapping at Catra.

Claws have dug into Catra’s chest, leaving large gashes through her fur. Adora gasps, her face contorting into a snarl as she lunges

for the beast. Her hands dig into its fur as she wraps her legs around it and holds its neck in chokehold.

Catra coughs, wiggling in the dirt before she glows a soft red and then she’s there again, wrapped in armor as she crawls towards the glinting of Adora’s dropped bracelet.

Adora grunts as the beast tries to reach back and snap at her neck, its sharp teeth coming a bit too close for comfort. Adora feels a sharp pull in her stomach and She-ra fizzles out, leaving Adora strangling the beast much less effectively.

“Adora!” Adora jerks up, Catra throws the sword towards her, one hand wrapped around her chest as if to keep the blood leaking from her scratches in her body.

Adora manages to catch it. Fumbling just a bit before her grip tightens with her heart in her throat. She plunges it into the beasts wiggling back. The beast yowls, wiggling and thrashing in Adora’s grip as it slowly lowers to the ground. Catra stumbles towards her, one bloody hand held out as if to help her down.

The jeering crowd of clones go crazy, frothing at the drop into the ring. The leader, the one covered in fur, yells in outrage gesturing at clones and pointing at Catra and Adora in the middle of the ring.

They have time to even run before the side of the cavern explodes outwards.

Adora wraps Catra in her arms and shields her as rock rains down, Catra huddles against Adora chest, her face dug into her neck. Clones screech louder than any of the cheering and jeering ever got. Catra flinches further into Adora.

The fleeting memory of Catra telling them to get to high ground before the bomb explodes flies across her brain but then she's too focused on the way the floor shakes, then cracks and then crumbles.

A flash bang should not have caused this much damage. Adora is starting to wonder what bomb Glimmer picked up before they trekked into the tunnel.

“This isn’t good” Catra says, her voice weak and tired as the floor cracks just below them. The ground drops out from below them and Adora tightens her grip as they fall. She grunts as her back hits rock but she doesn’t stop moving, sliding down the slanted tunnel like a slide, screaming clones and thousands of pounds of rubble follow.

Adora hadn’t realized how far they had traveled up to get to the clone stronghold. It must have right over the Bright-moon dam. The slide opens into the sky and Catra and Adora are hurtling towards the water. Just before the dam and below that a vast lake.

“I will never forgive you if you let me drown” Catra screams into Adora’s ear. Or atleast Adora thinks that is what Catra says before they plunge into the icy waters.

The shock to her system keeps Adora from moving at all. As if she’s frozen. Then Catra is squirming in her grasp, taking handfuls of water and shoving them under her in an attempt to get back to the surface.

Adora shakes her head as much as she can beneath the water before following Catra’s lead, grasping the weak feline in her arm and using the other one to drag them towards the surface. She tries not to notice the brief pink water that floats from Catra’s chest.

Adora gasps as their faces break the water, hauling Catra on top of her. The feline’s head weakening falls back onto Adora’s shoulder. Adora struggles briefly to fight the current but it’s no use, she instead lets it drag them towards the dam as she swims to the side, towards the shore.

Her arm is tight around Catra’s warm midsection as she finally grasps the grassy shore. She grips onto roots and lifts one leg over the side before rolling Catra’s body onto the grass.

Adora is quickly dragged back under by two hands on her ankle. She kicks and struggles, her eyes catching on the blurry outline of a clone as it drowns. She shoves her foot into its head and it slips away in the current.

Adora grasps back onto the shore and drags her body up, gasping for air and whipping her head up to look at Catra. Adora had been swept a little ways away but not far.

Adora struggles to her feet, her eyes on Catra as the feline stumbles towards her. Catra has her arms wrapped over her chest, her eyelids blinking slowly as if she’s having trouble keeping them open,

“Catra” Adora says, catching the feline as she collapses into Adora’s arms. “Catra, oh my-”

“Hey Adora” Catra coughs, a bit of bloody spittle lands on her lower lip.

“No, no, no” Adora hands try to put pressure on Catra’s chest. Catra smiles her ear laying right above Adora's heart.

“I’m sorry I gave you a magic crisis” she whispers, one hand landing on Adora’s neck and cupping the juncture of her shoulder. “She-ra would be super helpful right now”

“I just need a bit of your magic” Adora stutters, her hands shaking as she pulls Catra closer. “Hot wire, remember?”

Catra laughs a bit, “sorry babe, You take a lot of Magic to hot wire. I’m all out”

“I can’t-” Adora takes Catra's hand and presses it against her own chest, as if to show Catra that her magic isn’t there. “It’s not there. I can't touch it”

Catra tilts her head at her, her tail shifting lazily beside her. “It’s all there Adora. Can’t you feel it?”

Adora shakes her head, trying to jeep the hot tears at bay as she watches Catra blink slower and slower. Catra smiles weekly and pulls Adora closer.

“Close your eyes” Adora opens her mouth to protest but Catra cuts her off, “close ‘em”

Adora squeezes her eyes shut, leaning down and resting her forehead against Catra’s to feel the felines breath against her face.

“I can feel it,” Catra whispers, patting just above Adora's heart, moving Adora’s hand with her. “I can feel it right there, humming with the magic all around us. In sync and on tune. A beautiful melody”

Adora listens, begging the silence to sing for her too. All she hears is Catra’s labored breathing. The wet coughing of clones as they drown in the river. The water lapping at the shore. The plopping of stone and wall falling from the ceiling and into the water.

The feeling of Catra’s soft fur against her temple and the fanning of breath across her face. Catra’s purring and then she’s humming. Low and beautiful.

Adora’s mouth drops open at the sound. Like a tone key it draws Adora’s ear. She can hear it. She can hear it. Catra is humming in melody with Adora. She focuses harder and can hear her own melody, The air around her warms. Glows a soft gold. Catra's body melts into her arms and Adora jerks.

When she opens her eyes Catra is smiling at her. Her chest no longer gushes blood. The only evidence that it ever did is the rips in her shirt. Adora cradles her in her arms. She-ra isn't there in form but Adora can feel her in her chest, in her body.

Catra smiles leaning back just a bit lazily before hooking a hand around her neck and kisses her. Adora, shocked, doesn’t hesitate to kiss her back. Pressing into Catra’s soft lips and reveling in the feeling of a tail wrapped around her calf.

When she pulls back Catra leans into Adora’s arms and pats her cheek. She’s breathing heavily and smiling just a bit. “That was a good second date but I don't put out until the third”

Adora chokes on her own saliva.

Chapter End Notes

I was briefly a life guard so I want you all to know the way Adora drags Catra out of the water is completely text book.

anyway leave a comment and a kudos if you enjoyed!!

I had fun writing it but let me know guys.

End Notes

thanks for reading!

tell me what you think in the comments

go look at ilikeyoucatradora's post on insta

https://www.instagram.com/p/CuAZreEgV5a/?utm_source=ig_web_copy_link&igshid=MzRlODBiNWFlZA==

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